



PERSONAL WORKBOOK

5 Steps to Rebuild Your Life After Cancer

A guided workbook to help you move from surviving to fully living

PERSONAL EDITION

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A Note Before You Start

This workbook is a coaching tool. It is not medical advice, and it is not therapy. If you are struggling with your mental health, please speak to your GP or a qualified mental health professional. You deserve that support too.

What this workbook is: an honest, private space to ask yourself the questions that matter most during the remission journey. Some of them will be hard. None of them have wrong answers. Write what is true for you, not what sounds right.

You do not need to complete it all at once. Work through one step at a time. Give each step the space it deserves.

Nobody will read this but you.

IF YOU NEED SUPPORT RIGHT NOW

Macmillan Cancer Support: macmillan.org.uk | 0808 808 00 00

Marie Curie: mariecurie.org.uk | 0800 090 2309

Samaritans (24 hours): samaritans.org | 116 123

Maggie's Centres: maggies.org

NHS: nhs.uk

How to Use This Workbook

Each step has two exercises. They are short. But they are not easy. They ask you to be honest with yourself in ways that most people never are.

The suggestion is to take one step per week. Read it. Sit with the exercises across a few days. Do the commitment. Then move on.

1**Week 1 -- Allow Yourself to Feel**

Stop performing. Start telling the truth, at least to yourself.

2**Week 2 -- Understand Your Fear**

Name what is really going on underneath the scan anxiety and the 'I'm fine.'

3**Week 3 -- Rebuild Your Identity**

Work out who you are choosing to become, not who you were before.

4**Week 4 -- Reconnect**

With the people who matter. With your purpose. With your own body.

5**Week 5 -- Design Your Fuller Life**

Give yourself permission to want more than just survival.

There is also a letter to your future self at the end. Do not skip it.

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STEP ONE

Allow Yourself to Feel What You Actually Feel

FROM MARCELO

After my first diagnosis, I became very good at reassuring everyone around me. My family, my friends, my colleagues. I said 'I'm fine' so many times it started to feel true. It wasn't.

The feelings I was actually carrying, fear, anger, grief, a kind of loneliness I had never felt before, had nowhere to go. They did not disappear. They just went underground.

This step is about finding them. Not to be dramatic. But because you cannot build something real on feelings you are pretending not to have.

EXERCISE 1

The Gap Between What You Say and What You Feel

Think about the last time someone asked how you were doing. You gave them an answer. Now answer honestly, for yourself only.

What do you typically say when someone asks how you are?

What are you actually feeling that you rarely, or never, say out loud?

Who, if anyone, gets the real answer? If nobody does, why not?

EXERCISE 2

Name It

Below is a list of emotions. Circle or underline every one you have felt since your diagnosis, even briefly, even if it surprised you. Then answer the question below.

Relief Fear Anger Grief Guilt Loneliness Numbness Gratitude Confusion
Exhaustion Hope Resentment Sadness Peace Emptiness Pretending Loss
Invisible Changed Uncertain

Which of these have you never spoken about to another person? Why?

MY COMMITMENT THIS WEEK

I will say one true thing to one person this week that I would normally hold back. What is it, and who will I say it to?

2

STEP TWO

Understand the Fear and Learn to Live Alongside It

FROM MARCELO

I used to think fear of recurrence would fade once enough time had passed. It did not. What changed was my relationship with it.

I stopped trying to argue myself out of it, or stay busy enough to outrun it. I started asking it questions instead. What are you actually afraid of? What is this fear costing you? What would you do today if the fear were not in charge?

That shift, from fighting the fear to getting curious about it, changed everything.

EXERCISE 1

What Is the Fear Really Costing You?

Fear of recurrence is real and it is valid. But often it does more damage than just making us anxious. It quietly shapes our choices.

What have you stopped doing, avoided, or put off because of fear since your diagnosis?

If you knew, with certainty, that the cancer was not coming back, what would you do differently starting tomorrow?

What does that answer tell you about what the fear is actually costing you?

EXERCISE 2

A Conversation With Your Fear

This sounds unusual but it works. Write a short reply to your fear as if it were a person speaking to you. What is it actually trying to protect you from? What does it need from you?

My fear says:

What it is really trying to protect me from is:

What I want to say back to it is:

MY COMMITMENT THIS WEEK

One thing I have been avoiding because of fear that I will do this week, even if the fear is still there:

3

STEP THREE

Rebuild Your Identity on Your Own Terms

FROM MARCELO

I remember looking at photos of myself from before my diagnosis and feeling like I was looking at a different person. Not because I looked different, though I did. But because I was different.

The things that used to define me, my job, my social life, how I thought of myself as strong and unbreakable, no longer quite fitted. I spent a long time trying to go back to that person.

Eventually I understood I was not supposed to go back. I was supposed to go forward.

The question that changed things for me: not who was I, but who am I choosing to become?

EXERCISE 1

What Cancer Took. What It Gave.

This is not about being positive or finding a silver lining. It is about being honest about what has changed, in both directions.

What has cancer taken from your sense of who you are? (What did you lose?)

What, if anything, has it given you that you would not give back? (Be honest.)

Who were you trying to be before cancer that no longer feels true?

EXERCISE 2

Three Words

Strip everything back. Not your roles, not your job title, not what you do for others. Just you.

**If you had to describe the person you are becoming in three words, what would they be?
Not the person you were. The person you are moving towards.**

What would it look like to live more fully from those three words, starting this week?

MY COMMITMENT THIS WEEK

One decision I will make this week that reflects who I am becoming, not who I used to be:

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STEP FOUR

Reconnect With People, Purpose, and Your Body

FROM MARCELO

One of the strangest things about illness is what it does to relationships. Some people showed up in ways I never expected. Others, people I thought were close, disappeared. And I understood: cancer is a filter.

My relationship with my body changed too. I had spent my whole life inside it without really thinking about it. After diagnosis, it felt like something separate from me. Something that had failed me, or that I could not trust.

Reconnection with my body did not happen overnight. It started with very small things. A walk. A proper meal. Noticing when I felt warm. These things sound small. They were not.

EXERCISE 1

The People in Your Life Right Now

Be honest. Not everyone who was in your life before belongs in it in the same way now. And some people have stepped forward who deserve more of your time.

Who in your life genuinely gets it? Who makes you feel less alone in this?

Who do you find yourself performing wellness for? Who drains you?

Is there a conversation you have been putting off with someone who matters to you? What would you say if you were not afraid of their reaction?

EXERCISE 2

Your Relationship With Your Body

This one is personal. Your body has been through something enormous. Before you can rebuild, it helps to acknowledge where you actually are.

How would you describe your relationship with your body right now, in one honest sentence?

When did you last feel genuinely at home in your body? What were you doing?

What is one small, gentle thing you can do this week that is an act of kindness towards your body, not punishment, not pushing through, but genuine care?

MY COMMITMENT THIS WEEK

One relationship I will invest in this week, and one act of kindness I will show my body:

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STEP FIVE

Design Your Fuller Life

FROM MARCELO

This is the step I wish someone had given me earlier. Not the exercises. The permission.

Permission to want a life that is actually good. Not just bearable. Not just free of cancer. Good. Full. Honest. Worth getting up for.

You are not being greedy by wanting that. You are not being ungrateful. You are being a human being who has been through something hard and has come out the other side and is asking: what now?

That question is the beginning of everything. Answer it honestly.

EXERCISE 1

What Are You Waiting For Permission to Want?

Most people have things they genuinely want but have never let themselves fully admit, because they feel selfish, unrealistic, or too much. This is the space to write them down.

If you were being completely honest, what do you want from your life that you have not yet let yourself say out loud?

What is the story you tell yourself about why you cannot have it?

What if that story is not true?

EXERCISE 2

The View From a Year From Now

Imagine it is one year from today. You look back and think: that was when things started to change. What had to happen for you to think that?

A year from now, I want to feel...

The one area of my life I most want to look different is...

The first concrete step towards that, the one I will take this week, is...

MY COMMITMENT THIS WEEK

The one step I will take this week towards my fuller life. Not eventually. This week.

With love,

You Do Not Have to Do This Alone

You have just done something that takes genuine courage. You sat with the questions that most people spend years avoiding. That matters.

But a workbook can only take you so far. The real transformation happens in conversation. In the space where you can be fully honest without managing anyone else's feelings.

My name is Marcelo Marques. I am a resilience and remission coach based in London, and I have been through cancer twice. I work with people who have finished treatment and want to build something genuinely meaningful on the other side of it.

I offer a free 30-minute discovery call. No obligation. No sales pitch. Just an honest conversation about where you are and what might help.

Book Your Free Discovery Call

A 30-minute conversation. Honest and without pressure.

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Surviving was never the whole point. Living fully is.

*With warmth, **Marcelo***

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